

| By Mihir Srivastava |

S omalia's pirates may be making waves worldwide, but another African country is the origin of a global crime wave of sorts—Nigeria. India is a preferred target for Nigerian nationals with a criminal bent of mind, whose repertoire includes drug peddling, lottery scams and cybercrime. P.K. Shareef, an NRI from Kannur who works in Qatar, was made to believe he had inherited property worth \$15 million from a billionaire. Shareef was duped into shelling out as much as Rs 40 lakh for "processing the documents". The case led to the arrest of a Nigerian national, Saba Abdul Razakh, the first in India in what is popularly known as "Nigerian 419" email fraud. Razakh was arrested recently in Bangalore when he was to deliver the "fortune".

Epicentred in the West, 'Nigerian fraud' is now a worldwide web, with India a prime target. Sample this, from the US State Department's latest travel advisory for South/Central Asia-India: "West African/Nigerian fraud rings are also active in Mumbai. These cons target the victim's need or greed for quick money or ignorance of sound business practice... it is not uncommon for these groups to use the names of actual American diplomats or businessmen."

The email lottery con, a message in your inbox announcing a great business deal or millions of dollars won in a lottery, continues to snag more and more victims. As does what is known as the Black dollar fraud. The Chennai Police arrested Davidson, a Nigerian operating from Delhi, in February for duping a software engineer of Rs 3.5 lakh. "The accused told the victim—Laxmikant Nayak from Orissa—that the money will be coated black to avoid customs trouble, and he could clean it with a solution later," said an investigator. The accused told Nayak that one litre of the solution would cost Rs 1.6 lakh

and even demonstrated the cleaning process. Similar cases have been reported from the Capital, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh and other states.

Then there are credit card scams. In July last year, three Nigerians were arrested for using forged credit cards. The police seized seven fake cards. The three men had also hacked several accounts to steal Rs 33.5 lakh, transferring the funds many times to throw off pursuers.

Drug peddling is also high on the Nigerian list in India: In as many as 80 per cent of cases where a foreign

national was caught peddling drugs, the person involved was Nigerian. Delhi's Tihar Jail has about 100 Nigerians booked mostly in drug-related cases, says Sunil Gupta, the jail's law officer. The Nigerians arrested are usually between 30 and 45 years of age. Most come on a business Visa for 'garment exports'. The Intelligence Bureau worries over the Afghanistan-Taliban connection in the drug trade. Half of the 10-odd cases of drug smuggling involving Nigerians where arrests were made by the Delhi Police involved Afghans.

Pros of CON

From credit card fraud to drug peddling and job scams, Nigerians seem to be everywhere in the crime business



**JOHN KENNETH WAS RECENTLY ARRESTED
IN DELHI ON CHARGES OF FRAUD**